

Spacing with margin, padding, and gap

In the last few lessons, you used padding, margin, width, borders, radius, and shadows. You can now make individual boxes look better, so the next step is spacing the whole page.

Good spacing starts with one practical question: where should the space belong?

- Use `padding` for space inside a box.
- Use `margin` for space outside a box.
- Use `gap` for space between items in a group.

This lesson turns spacing into a repeatable habit.

Start with a cramped page

Use a small lesson page as the practice surface. Put this markup in

`index.html` :

html

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
  <head>
    <meta charset="UTF-8">
    <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1">
    <title>Spacing practice</title>
    <link rel="stylesheet" href="style.css">
  </head>
  <body>
    <main class="page">
      <section class="intro">
        <p class="eyebrow">CSS practice</p>
        <h1>Plan your next lesson</h1>
        <p class="summary">Spacing helps related things feel connected and separate thir</p>
      </section>

      <section class="lesson-list">
        <article class="lesson-card">
          <h2>Text and color</h2>
          <p>Review font size, line height, text color, and background color.</p>
        </article>

        <article class="lesson-card">
          <h2>The box model</h2>
          <p>Practice content, padding, border, and margin in DevTools.</p>
        </article>

        <article class="lesson-card">
          <h2>Sizing cards</h2>
          <p>Compare width, max-width, min-height, radius, and shadow.</p>
        </article>
      </section>
    </main>
  </body>
</html>
```



```
<div class="actions">
  <a class="primary-action" href="/start">Start practice</a>
  <a class="secondary-action" href="/review">Review notes</a>
</div>
</main>
</body>
</html>
```

Then add a basic stylesheet:

CSS

```
* {
  box-sizing: border-box;
}

body {
  font-family: system-ui, sans-serif;
  color: #111827;
  background-color: #f9fafb;
}
```

◀ Previous Lesson

Next Lesson ▶

```
.intro,
.lesson-card {
  background-color: white;
  border: 1px solid #e5e7eb;
}

.eyebrow {
  color: #2563eb;
  font-weight: 700;
}

.summary,
.lesson-card p {
  color: #4b5563;
  line-height: 1.6;
}
```

Open the page. The boxes exist, but the content is crowded and the page does not have a clear rhythm yet. That is what spacing fixes.

Choose a small spacing scale

Before adding random values, choose a small set of spacing numbers.

For this lesson, reuse this small spacing scale:

text

4px, 8px, 12px, 16px, 24px, 32px, 48px

You do not need a perfect design system yet. The point is to reuse a few values instead of inventing a new number for every property.

For example, you might use:

- **8px** for small gaps.
- **16px** for comfortable inner spacing.
- **24px** or **32px** for larger section spacing.



AI Tutor

What is a design system in UI design?



Consistent spacing makes a page feel calmer because the distances repeat.



Repeat spacing values - When spacing feels messy, the problem is often too many unrelated numbers. Reusing a small spacing scale usually makes the page feel more intentional.

Add padding inside boxes

Padding creates room inside a box. Let's add padding to the intro and cards:

CSS



```
.intro,
.lesson-card {
  background-color: white;
  border: 1px solid #e5e7eb;
  padding: 24px;
}
```

Reload the page and the text should no longer touch the box edges.

This is the same rule from the box model lesson: if the inside of a box feels cramped, use padding.

Add margin between sections

Margin creates space outside an element.

The intro, lesson list, and actions are separate parts of the page, so they need space between them.

Add margin below the intro and lesson list:

CSS



```
.intro {
  margin-bottom: 32px;
}

.lesson-list {
  margin-bottom: 24px;
}
```

Reload the page and the sections should feel more separated.

Use margin when the whole element needs distance from another element.
Do not use margin to fix text touching the inside of a box.

That distinction matters because the two properties solve different spacing problems:

- Padding fixes cramped content inside a background or border.
- Margin separates one element from another.

 **Do not use empty HTML for spacing** - Avoid adding empty `<p>` , `<br>` , or extra blank elements just to push things apart. Spacing belongs in CSS, not in fake HTML content.

Use gap between grouped items

`gap` creates space between items inside a group.

For `gap` to work, the group needs a layout mode like flex or grid. You will learn both properly later. For now, use one small flex row so you can see what `gap` does.

Add this to the action row:

CSS

```
.actions {
  display: flex;
  gap: 12px;
}
```

Now style the links enough to see the row clearly:

CSS

```
.primary-action,
.secondary-action {
  padding: 10px 14px;
  border-radius: 6px;
  text-decoration: none;
  font-weight: 700;
}

.primary-action {
  color: white;
  background-color: #2563eb;
}

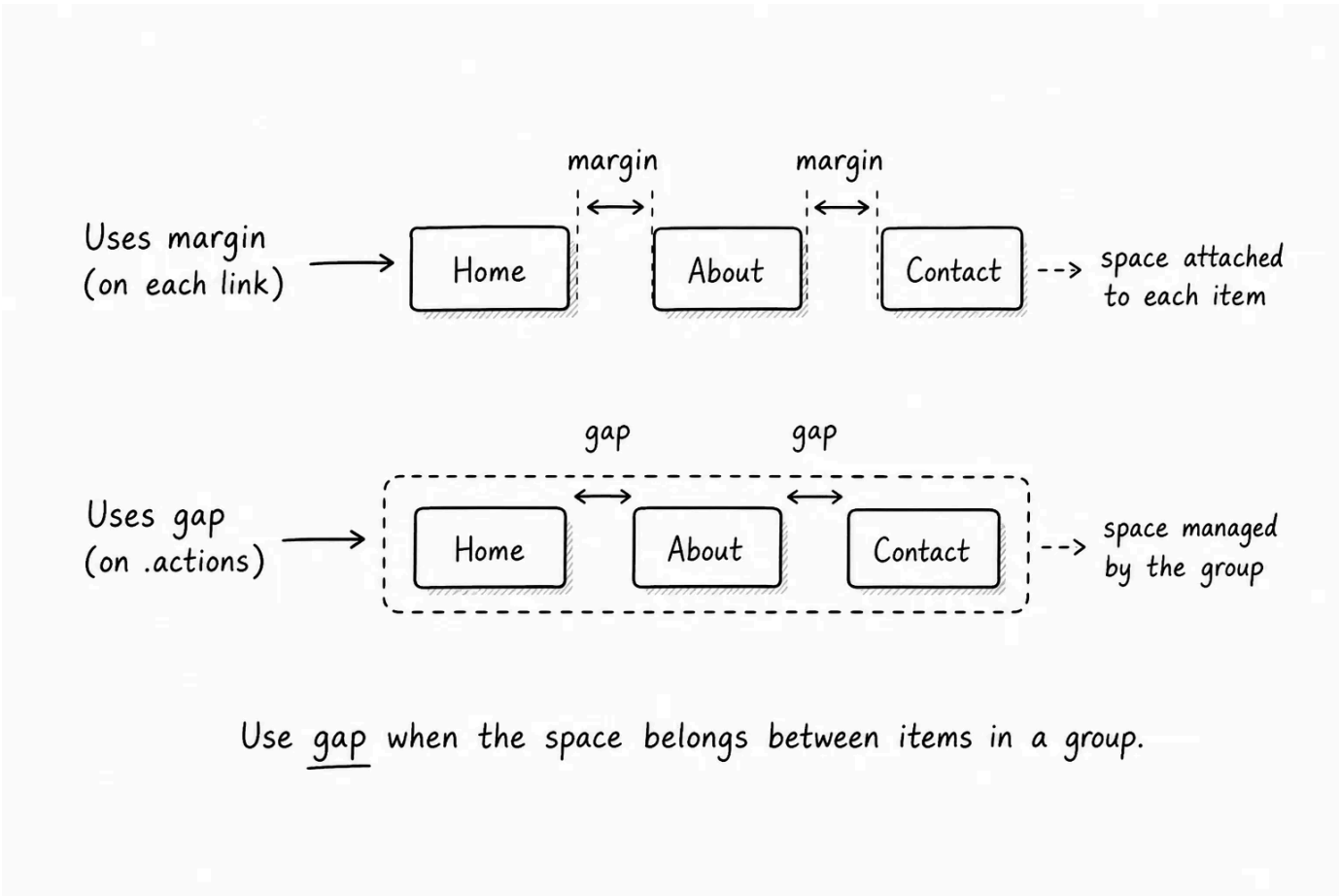
.secondary-action {
  color: #2563eb;
  border: 1px solid #bfdbfe;
}
```

Reload the page and the action links should sit in a row with space between them. The useful part is the parent-owned gap:

CSS

```
.actions {  
  gap: 12px;  
}
```

You do not need to add margin to each link. The parent group owns the space between its children.



Margin versus gap - `margin` creates space around an individual element, `gap` creates space *between* the child elements of an element.

Group the cards with gap

The lesson cards are also a group. Instead of adding `margin-bottom` to every card, let the parent manage the space.

Add the gap to the card list:

CSS

```
.lesson-list {  
  display: flex;  
  flex-direction: column;  
  gap: 16px;  
  margin-bottom: 24px;  
}
```

You will learn flexbox properly later. For now, notice the spacing behavior: the cards get consistent space between them because the parent `.lesson-list` owns the gap.

This is usually cleaner than putting margin on every card:

CSS

```
.lesson-card {  
  margin-bottom: 16px;  
}
```

That can work, but it often creates awkward extra space after the last item.

gap avoids that because it only creates space between items.

Where should the space belong?

When a page feels cramped or messy, ask where the space should live.

If the text is too close to the inside edge of a card, use padding:

CSS

```
.lesson-card {  
  padding: 16px;  
}
```

If two sections are too close together, use margin:

CSS

```
.intro {  
  margin-bottom: 32px;  
}
```

If items in a group need even space between them, use gap:

CSS

```
.lesson-list {  
  display: flex;  
  flex-direction: column;  
  gap: 16px;  
}
```

That one question solves a lot of beginner spacing confusion: where should the space belong?

🌟 AI Tutor

I am learning CSS spacing. Use my .intro, .lesson-list, .lesson-card, and .actions examples to quiz me on whether a spacing problem should use padding, margin, or gap. Ask me where the space belongs before explaining the answer.

>

Try it

Now test where spacing belongs by changing one spacing choice at a time:

- Change **.intro** padding from **24px** to **8px** , then back to **24px** .
- Change **.intro** **margin-bottom** from **32px** to **8px** , then to **48px** .

- Change `.lesson-list gap` from `16px` to `4px` , then to `24px` .
- Remove `display: flex` and `flex-direction: column` from `.lesson-list` and reload. Notice what happens to `gap` .
- Remove `display: flex` from `.actions` and reload. Notice what happens to `gap` .
- Add a fourth `.lesson-card` and check whether the spacing stays consistent.

For an extra challenge, add a small note under the action row:

html

<p class="helper-text">You can change these styles and reload the page after each edit.</p>

Use margin to separate it from the action row, and use color or font size only if the text needs to feel less important.

The goal is to stop asking, "Which spacing property should I use?" and start asking, "Where should this space belong?"

< 0 / 10 >

✔ Knew 0 Items

🌟 Learnt 0 Items

⏮ Skipped 0 Items

🔄 ResetProgress

Test Your Understanding

What does padding do?

[Click to Reveal the Answer](#)

✔ Already Know that

🌟 Didn't Know that

⏮ Skip Question

✓

LESSON COMPLETE

Nicely done.

Up next: Personal Portfolio

Next Lesson →